





SPORTS

TOP OF THEIR GAME

With yet another medal haul, squash players ***Joshna Chinappa, Saurav Ghosal and Dipika Pallikal Karthik*** *are proving that good things can come in threes*

As Joshna Chinappa and Saurav Ghosal geared up for the WSF World Doubles Squash Championship in early April, they did, of course, want to progress in the tournament and improve on their previous performances. But they shared another, more personal goal: They hoped to get their common partner, Dipika Pallikal Karthik, ready for the highest level of the sport again. Pallikal Karthik last played the US Open in 2018. After delivering twin boys in October 2021, she was now looking to make a comeback.

"We wanted to let her feel the intensity of tournament play again. She's been through a lot and your motivation kind of ebbs and flows a bit," says Ghosal. By the end of the week, Pallikal Karthik had two golds to her name. She first teamed up with Ghosal to take the mixed doubles final, and an hour later, partnered Chinappa to win the women's doubles title. It was India's best result at the event, a morale-boosting performance which came just in time, ahead of this year's Commonwealth and Asian Games.

Since 2010, **GHOSAL, CHINAPPA** and **PALLIKAL KARTHIK** have been the flagbearers of Indian squash. They know many hopes are pinned on them

"Since Dipika had been out for a while, she was obviously going to be targeted. We had to figure out how we could mask her weaknesses and accentuate her strengths as much as possible," Ghosal says. "We wanted to make the top four so that we got a decent seeding at the Commonwealth Games. Winning the entire event is a bonus, a cherry on top of the cake." The start-stop schedule during the pandemic slowed down both Chinappa and Ghosal. Once the tour got more consistent, the duo would fly to Chennai to spend time with Pallikal Karthik. "We started training as often as we could about four months back; our partnership on court has been effortless even though she was away," Chinappa says.